

Supervision Reflection Paper Assignment

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I have no known conflict of interest to disclose.

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It was a pleasure to join a graduate counseling intensive course as a part of this advanced group course. The experience reminded me that I love seeing eyes light up and ears perk up when students start to assimilate information into understanding. I appreciate the care and forethought of the Liberty faculty in leading students to competency in counseling dispositions. I learned much from the experience, but here are a few of my outcomes.

What did you learn about training/supervising group leaders?

The first thing I learned about supervising group leaders is that process is paramount. It is not enough to facilitate an environment of informational transfer. When supervising a group leader, we must lead the processing. As students begin to learn about the factors of group therapy, the implications of interpersonal interactions, and the interventions effective for moving the group into a working stage, they need us to hold a mirror. The mirror shows them not only what a textbook says should or could happen, it shows them what just happened in the group they are leading. The mirror validates the progress and mistakes alike. The mirror can help students embrace the idea that everything is “grist for the mill” (Yalom, 2020). As a supervisor processing the process of the process, students start to believe in the power of group. From the Monday of the first group session to the Wednesday of the final group I co-supervised, students were starting to get it. The leaders of the first group cannot be scrutinized too much. After all they had less to build from than the others. But what I noticed was that the leaders of Wednesday’s group were more attuned to interpersonal work and linking the members together than the leaders of Monday’s group. I don’t believe this is because Wednesday’s leaders were simply better leaders. I believe this is because they had the model and process of two previous groups to build upon.

This brings me to the second thing I learned by supervising group leaders. Start at the beginning. I was worried that I would not be able to supervise these students. I was concerned that I wouldn't be able to add anything to the process (which is a third outcome I will address soon). However, I was surprised by the competencies of the students. I mean that in no way as derogatory. In fact, I was reminded shortly after the course week started where I was in competency when I was in their shoes, not very far along! This reminder struck a chord with me and taught me that one must learn to crawl before one can walk.

The third outcome of this experience was learning that I have the skills to supervise individual and group counselors. I'm by no means stating a terminal understanding or finished work (as Paul the Apostle calls it). I am stating that what emerging counselors and students need is a fellow learner. One who is a step ahead of them but is not too proud or self-focused to share what they have learned before. Most of the reflections of the students during the week of supervision were on how and when I and the other supervisor learned what we were teaching. They seemed to be in awe at times of the language and intuition of the processing we were walking them through. Again, this isn't a reflection of my omniscience. It is a reflection of the experience I have and can share with others as we partner to help clients. There will always be more to learn. I will not stop listening to supervisees, colleagues, and students. But, I do not feel the need to wait on any particular revelation to see how I can be helpful.

What was most challenging about the supervisory experience?

I want to be careful that I do not sound arrogant, and I want to be careful not to communicate that the experience was easy or simple. There were challenging aspects of the supervisory experience as well. The most challenging aspect was the sense that this was not my group to supervise. My anxiety over the supervision part of the course was not due to what I

would say. I have sat with enough clients now to know I can't plan the dialogue. What caused the most anxiety was knowing I was also being assessed and, ultimately, could take the processing in a direction the professor did not agree with or desire. This is not new for me. I have stated for years that most of my anxiety is due to not knowing what people are thinking of me, things don't change sometimes. But being aware of this and recognizing that it doesn't mean I am getting it wrong or not accepted. I am thankful for Dr. Vuncannon who led me, as well as the students, with compassion and tact. I felt included and supported by his feedback.

What supervisory skills did you excel at, and which skills do you need to improve upon?

In this feedback I found some skills I both excelled at and some I need to improve upon. I excelled at reflecting on the students' experiences of the exercise. I was able to convey empathy and understanding as they sometimes lamented their ability to attend to the group members. Recalling my own experience of learning, I was able to validate and accurately empathize with their emotions. Once I recognized the direction and goal of debriefing the group experiences, I was also able to add a bit of teaching over the power of group. I excelled in summarizing the factors of group therapy and interpersonal interactions in a way that helped the students see how they had just played out before them. One group especially began bypassing the leaders to validate and interact with the other members of the group. Pointing out the working stage and how they affected each other through the social microcosm was fun. I was not great at everything though and I need to improve on challenging the student leaders to grow themselves. I found myself mostly over-validating their shortcomings. One student mentioned "saying the wrong thing" in an effort to connect one member to another. I over-validated by quoting Yalom's admonition that "everything is grist for the mill". While I don't hate that validation, I could have also challenged her to ask what she could do differently next time.

I appreciate this experience and feel I have grown from it. I am encouraged to and desire to supervise students and new counselors in the future. I am even more excited to take the supervision course and learn even more about supervising these emerging counelors.